further confirmation of his divine mission. ‘His Majesty spent whole nights in praising God,’ wrote Badauni. ‘He continually occupied himself in pronouncing Ya huwa (O God), and Ya hadi (O Guide) in which he was well versed.’ Akbar isolated himself from the swirl and skitter of his court and would spend nights sitting on a stone slab in a quiet cell, gratitude filling his heart ‘with his head bent over his chest, gathering the bliss of the early hours of dawn’. According to Badauni, Akbar had learnt that Sultan Sulaiman Karrani had been in the habit of praying every night in the company of religious men, and discussing matters of spirituality and philosophy with them, and so decided to build a separate hall in which to discuss the many questions that weighed on his soul and troubled his heart. ‘Discourses on philosophy have such a charm for me that they distract me from all else,’ he was to say later, ‘and I forcibly restrain myself from listening to them, lest the necessary duties of the hour be neglected.’ Akbar now ordered the building of an ibadat khana* at the site of the Mahdavi Abdullah Niyazi Sirhindi’s old quarters ‘consisting of four porticoes with separate seating arrangements for the nobles, sayyids, theologians (ulema) and the mystics’. Here Akbar began to hold weekly discussions on Thursday evenings when incense perfumed the air while the Padshah waited impatiently to offer gold coins to those who would dazzle with their arguments and articulate speech.

Also present at the meetings was Abu’l Fazl, now calling himself ‘allami’. ‘He is the man,’ wrote Badauni bitterly, ‘that set the world in flames.’ But that was much later, after Badauni had been humiliated and repudiated by Akbar and cast out from the warm glow of the Padshah’s attention. Of the two young men, it was initially Badauni who was the more intemperate and argumentative. When the two scholars happened to meet the orthodox jurist Abdullah Sultanpuri in 1572, it was Badauni who argued provocatively with him about the supposed heretical nature of a text, while Abu’l Fazl attempted discreetly to silence him. ‘You have passed through a great danger,’ Abu’l Fazl chided Badauni after the meeting, ‘but (fortunately) he did not set himself to persecute you. Had he done so, who could have saved you?’

For now, however, both men, untethered and wandering, were looking to be saved from their many demons by this Padshah who promised new horizons and brighter futures. They were both given a mansab of 20 to begin with and thus these two old schoolmates were ‘both baked in one